attendants. Jouher was among them, as were the two rival anakas, Maham and Jiji, and Jiji's husband, Shamsuddin Muhammad. Perhaps they huddled protectively around their charge – Akbar was barely one year old; perhaps they prepared to battle on his behalf. When Askari arrived, however, riding in with his troops only hours after Humayun's departure, he was less menacing than he was impudent.

Why had Humayun 'gone off by the desert'?[9] he asked Shamsuddin, claiming cheekily that he'd only come to pay his elder brother his respects. For Akbar, he sent some fruit, then settled down with a couple of clerks to take full account of whatever treasures Humayun had left behind. It was only the next day that Askari went to meet his nephew – imprisoning most of Humayun's chieftains on his way. (Among them Tardi Beg, who was forced to bail himself out with a small fortune, and thus, writes Abul Fazl with satisfaction, he 'got the retribution of his deeds'.)

Akbar was a cheerful child, generous with his smiles. Not so with his uncle. Though Askari came to him with 'a jubilant air', Akbar would not be moved to smile. And why should he? As Askari muttered sadly to himself, 'We can see whose this child is. Why should he be elated at seeing us?' Instead, he made a grab for the ring his uncle had strung around his neck. Eager for a little affection, Askari took it off and gave it to Akbar immediately, but received no reward.[10]

In mid-December 1543, Askari and his glum nephew arrived in Qandahar. Askari gave him a room near his own, at the very top of the fortress, and his own wife, Sultan Begum, for a mother.[11] It was here, in this eagle's nest, that Akbar began to walk.

He liked to tell the story himself. The wrench that took him from Humayun's camp to Askari's castle was the kind of memory that does not fade with time. 'I perfectly remember what happened when I was one year old, and especially the time when [my father] proceeded towards Iraq and I was brought to Qandahar.' Here, as Akbar took his first unsteady steps about his room, tumbling into his various mamas' laps, Maham reminded Askari of an avuncular duty. It was a custom that when a child started walking, his father, or grandfather – and failing either, now, his uncle – would roll his turban in the toddler's way, whose tripping and falling would divert the evil eye. '[I]mmediately,' Akbar remembers, 'the Mirza . . . took